

Hands-on Workshop on Research Work

Writing the Background of the Study and Formulating the Research Problem

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Presentation Outline

From Research Topic to Research Problem

Selecting a Research Topic

Writing the Background of the Study

Management Example

Education Example

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Understanding the Research Problem

From Research Problem to Research Question

Comparing Three Examples

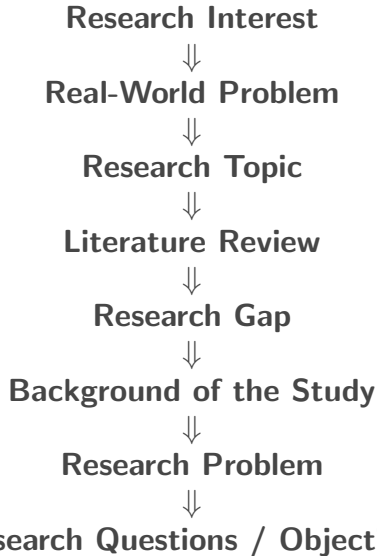
Common Mistakes

Hands-on Activity

Final Takeaway

From Research Topic to Research Problem

Where Are We Now?



Today's Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants should be able to:

- ▶ Explain what a research background is.
- ▶ Identify the essential components of a good background.
- ▶ Develop a logical background using the funnel approach.
- ▶ Distinguish between a research topic and a research problem.
- ▶ Formulate a clear and researchable problem statement.
- ▶ Develop research questions from a research problem.
- ▶ Develop research objectives from research questions.

Selecting a Research Topic

What Makes a Good Research Topic?

A good research topic should be:

- ▶ **Specific** – clearly defined.
- ▶ **Researchable** – can be investigated systematically.
- ▶ **Relevant** – addresses an important issue.
- ▶ **Manageable** – feasible within available time and resources.
- ▶ **Supported by literature** – sufficient previous research exists.
- ▶ **Data accessible** – relevant data can reasonably be obtained.
- ▶ **Interesting** – meaningful to the researcher.

From a Broad Area to a Specific Topic

Broad Area

Employee Motivation



Specific Area

Employee Motivation in Organizations



Specific Context

Employee Motivation in Commercial Banks



Topic Selection: Management Example

Broad Research Area

Human Resource Management

Research Interest

Employee Motivation

Observed Issue

Employees may experience different levels of motivation despite financial incentives and organizational policies.

Possible Research Topic

Factors Affecting Employee Motivation among Employees of Commercial Banks in Kathmandu Valley

Topic Selection: Education Example

Broad Research Area

Higher Education

Research Interest

Student Engagement in Online Learning

Observed Issue

Students increasingly use online learning platforms, but their level of engagement varies.

Possible Research Topic

Factors Affecting Student Engagement in Online Learning among University Students in Nepal

Topic Selection: Society Example

Broad Research Area

Society and Community

Research Interest

Social Media and Social Interaction

Observed Issue

Young people increasingly use social media, which may influence patterns of social interaction.

Possible Research Topic

Social Media Use and Social Interaction among University Students in Kathmandu Valley

Writing the Background of the Study

What Is the Background of the Study?

Definition

The background of the study explains the context of the research, why the issue is important, what is already known, what is not sufficiently known, and why the study is needed.

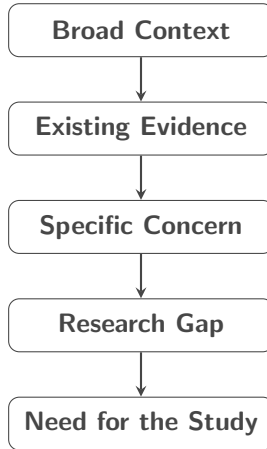
A good background answers:

1. What is happening?
2. Why is the issue important?
3. What do previous studies tell us?
4. What is the concern or problem?
5. What is missing or unclear?
6. Why is the present study necessary?

The Funnel Approach to Writing Background



The Logic of a Good Background



Key Principle

Research Methodology

Move from **general** to **specific**

What Should Each Paragraph Do?

1. **Paragraph 1 – Context**

Introduce the broader issue.

2. **Paragraph 2 – Importance**

Explain why the issue matters.

3. **Paragraph 3 – Existing Evidence**

Summarize what previous studies have found.

4. **Paragraph 4 – Problem / Gap**

Identify what remains unclear, inconsistent, or insufficient.

5. **Paragraph 5 – Need**

Explain why the present study is necessary.

Management Example

Management Example: Research Topic

Research Topic

Factors Affecting Employee Motivation among Employees of Commercial Banks in Kathmandu Valley

Possible factors:

- ▶ Compensation
- ▶ Leadership style
- ▶ Job satisfaction
- ▶ Recognition
- ▶ Organizational culture
- ▶ Working environment

Management Example: Background Logic

Employee Motivation



Important for organizational performance and service quality



Banking sector depends heavily on employees and service delivery



Employees may experience different motivational conditions



Previous studies identify several organizational factors



Importance of understanding the factors in the selected context



Need for the Study

Context-specific evidence is needed.

Management Example: Writing the Background

Paragraph 1 – Broad Context

Employee motivation is an important issue in human resource management because motivated employees may contribute to organizational performance and service quality.

Paragraph 2 – Context

The banking sector depends heavily on employee interaction, service delivery and organizational commitment. Employees may experience different motivational conditions related to compensation, leadership, recognition and working environment.

Paragraph 3 – Existing Evidence

Previous studies have examined factors such as salary, job satisfaction, leadership style, recognition and organizational culture in relation to employee motivation.

Management Example: Moving toward the Problem

Paragraph 4 – Problem / Gap

However, the relative importance of these factors may differ across organizational and cultural contexts. Evidence focusing specifically on employees of commercial banks in Kathmandu Valley may be limited or inconsistent.

Paragraph 5 – Need

Therefore, examining the factors associated with employee motivation among commercial bank employees can provide context-specific evidence for understanding employee motivation.

Notice the Movement

Context → Evidence → Concern → Gap → Need

Management Example: Formulating the Problem

Situation

Employee motivation is important in the banking sector.

Concern

Employees may experience different levels of motivation.

Existing Knowledge

Previous studies identify several organizational factors.

Gap

The evidence may be limited or inconsistent in the selected context.

Research Problem

There is insufficient context-specific evidence about the factors associated with employee motivation among employees of commercial banks in Kathmandu Valley.

Education Example

Education Example: Research Topic

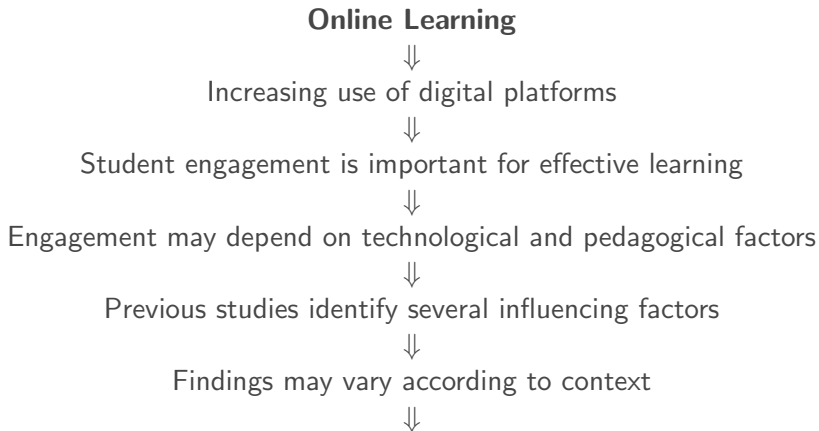
Research Topic

Factors Affecting Student Engagement in Online Learning among University Students in Nepal

Possible factors:

- ▶ Internet accessibility
- ▶ Digital literacy
- ▶ Teacher interaction
- ▶ Perceived usefulness
- ▶ Learning environment
- ▶ Technology-related factors

Education Example: Background Logic



Research Need

Context-specific evidence among university students in Nepal

Education Example: Research Problem

Situation

Online learning has become an important component of higher education.

Concern

Students differ considerably in their participation and engagement.

Existing Knowledge

Previous studies identify technological, pedagogical and learner-related factors.

Gap

The evidence may not adequately explain student engagement in the context of Nepalese universities.

Research Problem

There is limited context-specific evidence regarding the factors affecting student

Society Example

Society Example: Research Topic

Research Topic

Social Media Use and Social Interaction among University Students in Kathmandu Valley

Possible dimensions:

- ▶ Frequency of social media use
- ▶ Duration of use
- ▶ Purpose of use
- ▶ Face-to-face interaction
- ▶ Family interaction
- ▶ Peer interaction

Society Example: Background Logic

Social Media



Increasing use among young people



Provides opportunities for communication and networking



May influence patterns of social interaction



Previous studies report different relationships



Findings may differ according to population and context



Research Need

Evidence in the Nepalese context needs further investigation.

Society Example: Research Problem

Situation

University students increasingly use social media for communication.

Concern

Social media use may be associated with patterns of social interaction.

Existing Knowledge

Previous studies have examined relationships between social media use and social interaction.

Gap

The relationship is not sufficiently understood in the selected Nepalese context.

Research Problem

The relationship between social media use and social interaction among university students in Kathmandu Valley is not sufficiently understood.

Understanding the Research Problem

What Is a Research Problem?

Research Problem

A research problem is a clearly defined issue, situation, knowledge gap, inconsistency, or unanswered question that requires systematic investigation.

Important

A research problem is **not simply a research topic**.

Topic
 $\neq$
Research Problem

Topic $\neq$ Research Problem

Research Topic

Employee Motivation

Online Learning

Social Media

Public Service

Research Problem

Factors associated with employee motivation are not sufficiently understood in the selected context.

Factors explaining variation in student engagement are not sufficiently understood.

The relationship between social media use and social interaction is not sufficiently understood.

Barriers to accessing digital public services remain insufficiently understood.

Components of a Research Problem

A useful way to formulate a research problem is:



Simple Formula

Situation + Concern + Evidence + Gap + Need

Questions to Ask When Formulating a Problem

Ask yourself:

1. What is happening?
2. Who is affected?
3. What is the concern?
4. What do we already know?
5. What remains unknown or unclear?
6. What evidence supports the problem?
7. Why is the problem important?
8. Can the problem be investigated systematically?

From Research Problem to Research Question

Research Problem → Research Question

Research Problem

There is limited context-specific evidence regarding the factors affecting student engagement in online learning among university students in Nepal.



Research Question

What factors affect student engagement in online learning among university students in Nepal?



Research Objective

To examine the factors affecting student engagement in online learning among university students in Nepal.

Problem, Question and Objective

Research Problem What needs to be investigated?

Research Question What exactly do we want to know?

Research Objective What will the researcher do to answer the question?

Remember

The research question should directly arise from the research problem.

A Simple Formula for Writing a Research Problem

General Structure

Although **[what is known / what is happening]**, **[specific problem or concern]** remains insufficiently understood, particularly in **[context / population]**. Therefore, this study will investigate **[specific issue]**.

Example

Although online learning has become increasingly common in higher education, student engagement varies considerably and the factors associated with this variation remain insufficiently understood among university students in Nepal.

Comparing Three Examples

Three Fields: Topic and Research Problem

Field	Topic	Research Problem
Management	Employee Motivation	Factors associated with employee motivation are not sufficiently understood among commercial bank employees in Kathmandu Valley.
Education	Online Learning	Factors explaining variation in student engagement in online learning are not sufficiently understood among university students in Nepal.
Society	Social Media	The relationship between social media use and social interaction among university students in Kathmandu Valley is not sufficiently understood.

From Topic to Research Problem

Research Topic



What is happening?



Background of the Study



What is the concern?

Common Mistakes

Common Mistakes in Writing the Background

- ▶ Starting with a very broad discussion without reaching the research issue.
- ▶ Giving statistics without explaining their relevance.
- ▶ Writing a topic instead of a research problem.
- ▶ Making unsupported claims about a research gap.
- ▶ Claiming “no study has been conducted” without evidence.
- ▶ Listing many unrelated problems.
- ▶ Writing a problem that is too broad to investigate.
- ▶ Jumping directly from the topic to data collection.
- ▶ Using literature merely to summarize studies instead of building an argument.

The Golden Rule

Every paragraph should move the reader forward.

Context → Evidence → Concern → Gap → Need



Research Problem → Research Question → Research Objective

Hands-on Activity

Activity: Develop Your Research Problem

- Step 1:** Select one research interest.
- Step 2:** Identify a specific research topic.
- Step 3:** Search for 5–10 relevant studies.
- Step 4:** Identify what is already known.
- Step 5:** Identify what is missing, inconsistent or unclear.
- Step 6:** Write a 150–200 word background.
- Step 7:** Write one research problem.
- Step 8:** Convert the problem into one research question.
- Step 9:** Write one corresponding research objective.

Activity Worksheet

Research interest

Research topic

Real-world problem

What is already known?

What is missing / unclear?

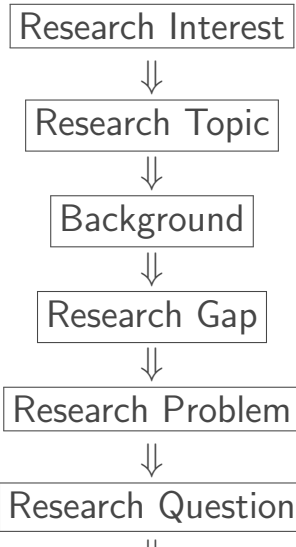
Research gap

Research problem

Research question

Final Takeaway

The Complete Logic



Key Takeaway

A topic tells us what we want to study.

The background explains why it matters.

The research problem tells us what needs to be investigated.

Interest → Problem → Question → Evidence → Knowledge

Remember

A well-defined research problem is the foundation of a successful research study.

Thank You

Questions and Discussion

From curiosity to evidence, research is a journey of systematic inquiry.